After 1980: what later research says about nomadology

When Deleuze and Guattari wrote the plateaus, they worked from the anthropology and archaeology of the 1970s. Those fields have changed a great deal in the decades since. Some of their findings bear out nomadology's claims. Others complicate them, and on a few points they dispute the plateaus outright. What pattern emerges? On the whole, the plateaus are most convincing when we take them as a theory of operations (the forming of a stock or the grading of a flight). Yet they are at their weakest when they make claims about origins or about which came first, which is why each row ends on a question for a new nomadology.

Claim	The record bears it out	The record complicates it	The record disputes it	What it asks of a new nomadology
The nomad holds a space and "does not move" 380-81, 410	Maroons who "settled right where they were" (Diouf 4-5), and Haitian cultivators who "ceased being cultivators" without leaving the plantation (Casimir 142)	Ancient DNA and isotopes measure displacement, which is migration, not holding (Kristiansen, Furholt). Humphrey and Sneath replace "nomadism" with "mobile pastoralism" (1)	Sneath attacks the egalitarian nomad as a trope and finds aristocracies on the steppe (*The Headless State* 3-4, 198-99)	**What evidence could register inhabiting a place without settling it, as opposed to crossing it?**
Numbering numbers, which came from the nomads 387-94	The colonial grading of flight as a numbered number, used to set punishments (Thompson 53)	Qin counties were defined by "a notional five hundred hearths" in the century of the first steppe decimal system (Sneath 237 n. 30). The Lupaqa khipu counted households (Murra)	Steppe decimal units belonged to hereditary aristocracies, with "lords of ten thousand" in name only (Sneath 3-5, 23)	**Keep numbering and numbered as two operations, distributing in space or dividing it, and drop the claim that numbering came first (389)**
The war machine is exterior, and war does not produce the State 351, 359	Steppe states formed "in relation to sedentary states" such as China (Di Cosmo 171). Lindner treats lineage as recruitment and defection (690, 697)	Kradin's Xiongnu captured outward by raiding and extortion while staying segmentary inside (77, 86)	Munkh-Erdene argues "for the nomadic origin of the state" in a warlord's warband (*The Nomadic Leviathan* 1, 25)	**Can command exist without the State-form? (357, 393)**
Societies ward off the State they anticipate, and any change past their limit 357-59, 431-33	Equality "asserted" through the ability to leave and weapons held by all (Woodburn 431, 436). Sharing as a test of relations (Peterson). Leach's Kachin oscillate instead of climbing	Resisting extraction pushed Tongan communities to stress women's reproductive roles (Gailey xi). Ritual knowledge founds rank as "looking after" (Myers 220-21). People hide food from their own kin (Peterson 864)	Boehm's "reverse dominance hierarchy" and Sterelny, both in Protevi (RoV 98), turn the operation into an evolved disposition	**Warding off takes work. Whose work is it?**
The Urstaat presupposes itself 427, 448	Early states were "more aspirational than operational" yet "presumptive of an integrated sovereign authority" (Richardson 2012, 4). Kings co-opted local powers they could not erase (Moreno García and Richardson 6)	State violence was "rare in fact" (Garfinkle and Richardson 161), which tells against the despot's terror without touching capture presupposing itself	·	**Keep presupposition as the operation, and drop the imagery of terror**
Comparison presupposes appropriation 444	Uruk scribes booked workers "just as" herds (Englund 176-77). A stock is rights converging "upon a single interest" (Ingold 553)	Sabi Abyad's many seals recorded a store shared "probably along egalitarian lines" (Frangipane 2018, 83). Indus standard weights turn up where wealth differs little (Green 159)	For Protevi, comparison and appropriation are "analytically separable" (RoV 176 n. 3)	**Is comparison a measure owned by one party and applied to others? Can a town compare without appropriating?**
The stock follows capture 428-29, 440	The order of storage and settled life is "chicken-and-egg" (Testart 524), and inequality "cannot be deduced" from storage (Ingold 553). Storage is one of four responses to risk (Halstead and O'Shea)	Mayshar and colleagues put appropriability before surplus (2022, 1092), though they locate it in the crop and not in a relation	Sterelny's storage threshold (RoV 98)	**When something is stored, is it a reserve kept in common, or a stock drawn toward a single interest?**

ATP pages refer to the Minnesota translation of *A Thousand Plateaus* (1987), RoV to Protevi's *Regimes of Violence* (2025). Every page number comes from a reading card checked against the text (*notes/working-file/06_reading_cards.md*). Empty cells mean that no work read for this project disputes the claim.

After 1980, continued

Claims 8-15, from the town to the archive.

Claim	The record bears it out	The record complicates it	The record disputes it	What it asks of a new nomadology
Town and State are two thresholds 432-34	Indus cities had writing, weights, seals, and metallurgy without palaces (Green 154). Cities served as refuges, with nomadism produced by urban flight (Yoffee 60)	Arslantepe had central institutions without a city (Frangipane 2012). Teotihuacan was founded by displaced people and governed corporately (Manzanilla). Fletcher's settlements have "an almost indefinable edge" (xxiii)	·	**What common measure belongs to the town, as distinct from the State's comparison?**
Capitalism wins through the State-form, not the town-form, and makes the ecumenical its own 434-37, 454	Steppe pastoralists were "key players" among "core" civilizations while staying "strategically independent and small-scale" (Frachetti 2). For Amin, no "pure theory of international relations" is possible (*Unequal Development* 131-32)	A world-economy "always has an urban centre of gravity, a city," from Venice and Antwerp to Amsterdam (Braudel, *The Perspective of the World* 27). In medieval Italy, Flanders and Germany, "the town won entirely" for a time (Braudel, *Capitalism and Material Life* 397)	·	**Which processes compose capitalism in a given time and place, and which still work against it?**
Four regimes of violence: struggle, war, crime, policing 447-48	"State terror" came before its use by the State's enemies (Richardson 2016)	Sanction by reputation and exclusion did most of the work in Middle Bronze Age Mesopotamia (Garfinkle and Richardson 161). Old Babylonian law treated flight as theft by whoever helped (Richardson 2023, 19-20)	·	**Is sanction without violence policing, or a fifth regime?**
Royal science captures nomad science 362-68	Rice knowledge was captured along with its bearers, with the task measured by the ditch (Carney 99). Caste and royal investiture separated the forge from kingship (Herbert 26, 138). Even the trials that farmers ran on their own fields were taxed, so as to fund the science that would replace them (Richards 160)	Maroon Science, learned through "testing and evasion," is a science whose object is capture itself (Bilby 4). Tracking reasons by hypothesis and deduction, the epistemology ATP gives royal science (Liebenberg 3)	·	**Extend nomad science to sciences of evasion, and add the routes of capture ATP lacks: caste, the unit of work, the tax**
The secret and the cipher 390	Saramaka history is kept restricted and "told in fragments," with experts "on a single hand" (Price, *First-Time* 7-8, 21)	Ritual knowledge escapes demand sharing (Peterson 868) and founds hierarchy without a State (Myers 220-21). Kromanti ceremonies are performed for tourists (Bilby 14)	·	**Restricted knowledge both founds hierarchy and shields those who keep it against capture. Who holds the measure of access?**
Smooth space will not save us (Protevi's marronage) 387, 500; RoV 96-120	The campo negro ("black countryside"), a formation "inside slavery and an alternative to it" (Gomes 282). Three processes in one swamp (Sayers 105-08)	The treaty of 1739 turned Jamaica's Maroons into an instrument of capture (Campbell 130). Grades of flight were a planters' metric (Thompson 53)	Roberts's *Freedom as Marronage* (2015) enlarges flight into a general model	**The colonial word marronage merges the nomad who stays in place with the migrant who flees. Split it**
The empires vanish when a war machine "bears down from without" 459	Teotihuacan's center was destroyed by "a premeditated, highly selective" action against the seats of power (López Luján et al. 13)	"What it is that is supposed to be collapsing" (Cowgill). At Arslantepe, new chiefs ruled by "managing the conflicts" (Frangipane 2012, 239). States regenerate by emulation (Schwartz 7)	Tainter's return to "lower complexity" is evolutionism run backward	**How can the end of a capture be named from somewhere other than the State?**
History is one with the triumph of States 393-94	The tribe as the settled archive's prey (Lindner). The 1769 map of a quilombo was drawn by the expedition sent to destroy it (Carney and Rosomoff 85). Trouillot's silences in the making of the archive	Regional survey records "distributions of artifacts in space," not only sites (Dunnell and Dancey 267). A Gini coefficient over house sizes is itself a numbered number (Kohler et al.)	·	**Work from distributions, not absences. An absence of material is not evidence of refusal**

ATP pages refer to the Minnesota translation of *A Thousand Plateaus* (1987), RoV to Protevi's *Regimes of Violence* (2025). Every page number comes from a reading card checked against the text (*notes/working-file/06_reading_cards.md*). Empty cells mean that no work read for this project disputes the claim.

Research since 1980, by area

After stage theory fell out of favor, no whole school in these fields has worked the way nomadology does. Rather, several smaller areas of research have done so in part, and it is these that we place here. For each area, the table gives what it studies (which of the five processes it examines, capture for instance) along with its way of working, as some areas follow their material while others impose a model on it. Its relation to nomadology then appears on a single scale, from nearest to farthest, with each judgment made about a work rather than about its author.

● convergent: works the way nomadology does ○ complementary: a sound account of one process, such as capture ○ source of evidence, with the frame set aside ◌ nominal affinity: shares the vocabulary, not the method ● antithetical

Area of research	Representative works	What it studies	How it works	Relation to nomadology	What to take from it	What it leaves out
Maroon history and archaeology after 1979	Gomes, Diouf, Sayers, Weik, Casimir, Bilby, Price's *First-Time*, Carney and Rosomoff	Marronage, with capture around it	Social history, historical archaeology, ethnography under restriction	● Convergent	A positive account of the outside, in which holding in place counts as much as departure	*Rarely compared with other formations*
Hunter-gatherer ethnography of sharing and storage	Woodburn, Peterson, Myers, Ingold 1983, Testart's reply	Warding off, described in operation	Ethnography	○ Complementary on warding off	Equality asserted, the stock as a relation, knowledge as the stock that warding off does not level	·
Indigenous and captured sciences	Richards, Carney, Herbert, Gladwin, Detienne and Vernant	Nomad science and its capture	Field research, history	● Convergent, in part	Capture by caste, by the unit of work, by the tax, and knowledge that exists only in operation	·
Mesopotamian economic history	Richardson, Garfinkle and Richardson, Steinkeller, Hudson and Van De Mieroop, Englund, Moreno García	Capture, set against the record's view of itself	Philology, economic history	○ Complementary on capture	The presumptive State, the uncounted, people booked like herds, violence mostly represented	*Little about life outside the archive*
Egalitarian urbanism and recording	Green on the Indus, Frangipane on Sabi Abyad and Arslantepe, Manzanilla on Teotihuacan, Yoffee, Fletcher	The town, and capture without a city	Site archaeology, synthesis	○ Complementary on the town	Towns and recording without the State, collapse as redistribution	*The town's own measures, not yet theorized*
The planters' metric	Thompson, Campbell	Capture through and inside marronage	History	○ Complementary on capture	Grades of flight as a numbered number, the treaty as capture by pact	·
Steppe revisionism	Sneath, Munkh-Erdene, Humphrey and Sneath, Lindner, Frachetti	Mostly capture (aristocratic order, nomadic statehood), Lindner the war machine	History, historical anthropology	○ Source of evidence	The decimal institution, with muster set against assessment. The disagreement about concepts is real	*Defines nomadism by movement, which ATP refuses*
Stage evolutionism, neo-evolutionism, cliodynamics	Service, Fried, Flannery 1972, Turchin's Seshat, Tainter	Capture	Coded variables, types, sequences	● Antithetical	Data only	*Stages, seen from the State*
Comparative early state, heterarchy, dual processes	Claessen and Skalník, Khazanov, Blanton, Crumley	Capture	Types, interpretive comparison	◌ Nominal affinity	·	*Stages and typologies return, and no exteriority*
Anarchist archaeology and the voluntarist synthesis	Angelbeck and Grier, Borck and Sanger, Graeber and Wengrow	Warding off	Voluntarist	◌ Nominal affinity	·	*Prevention without anticipation, choice in place of process*
The ontological turn and multispecies work	Viveiros de Castro, Descola, Kohn, Tsing	Thought of the outside, without process	Comparison of ontologies, patchiness	◌ Nominal affinity	·	*Capture disappears, and comparison is given up*
Assemblage archaeology	Harris, Fowler, Hamilakis and Jones, Olsen, Witmore	None: a flat ontology	Deleuzian vocabulary by way of DeLanda	◌ Nominal affinity	·	*No State-form, no nomad science*
Mobility science	Ancient DNA and isotopes (Kristiansen), Demoule's critique	Movement as population replacement	Genetics, isotopes	◌ Nominal affinity	Demoule, by contrast, is convergent: the steppe invasion as an artifact of the family tree	*Measures migration, not nomadism*

Placements from the project's source assessment (*work/assessment/source_assessment_v2.md*), which Jo may revise.

Neighboring fields

Nomadology is not confined to the fields it engages most often, which here are anthropology and archaeology, with history beside them. In their notes, Deleuze and Guattari also draw on mathematics, military theory, political economy and the history of science (Archimedes, Clausewitz, Marx, Husserl), and so must a new nomadology. Listed below are the neighboring fields that our reading has touched so far, each with what it offers a new nomadology.

Field	Works	What it offers nomadology
History of science and craft	Pamela Smith, *The Body of the Artisan* (2004). Detienne and Vernant, *Cunning Intelligence* (1974). Richards, *Indigenous Agricultural Revolution* (1985)	Craft knowledge outside the State's division of labor, and mētis ("cunning intelligence"), a knowledge that exists only in operation. Candidates for minor science
Navigation and tracking	Gladwin, *East Is a Big Bird* (1970). Liebenberg, *The Art of Tracking* (1990). The Shadow Wolves	The Puluwat navigator's vessel holds a place while the world passes (Gladwin 181-83), a local absolute. Once a border agency enlists them, trackers put following in the State's service
Prediction and platform labor	Breiman, "Statistical Modeling: The Two Cultures" (2001). Gray and Suri, *Ghost Work* (2019). Agre, "Surveillance and Capture" (1994). Galison on Wiener (1994)	The axiomatic predicting without a model of the process, a "last mile" of human tasks that shifts as each one is automated (Gray and Suri xxii), and capture as the reorganization of activity for tracking
Military theory	Brossollet, *Essai sur la non-bataille* ("Essay on the Nonbattle," 1975). Noyer, "De la notion de guérilla à la notion de techno-guérilla" ("From Guerrilla to Techno-Guerrilla," 1990). Lawrence	Brossollet is D&G's own source for the nonbattle and the "unspecified enemy." Noyer shows a State army taking up guerrilla technique. Theorists of the Israeli army have used ATP too (Weizman), which shows how widely its vocabulary has been taken up
Political economy of the ancient world	Hudson and Van De Mieroop, *Debt and Economic Renewal* (2002). Meillassoux, *The Anthropology of Slavery* (1986). Kohler et al. (2017)	Clean slates that keep dependents dependent on the palace, the sale that confirms a depersonalization already inflicted (capture presupposing itself), and wealth disparities measured as a numbered number
Political theory of the State and its outside	Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed* (2009). Simpson and Coulthard on Indigenous refusal. Moten and Harney	Scott's legibility is a sound account of comparison, though his hill peoples are known only through flight. Refusal against settler capture is a sound account of warding off. Fugitivity as ontology flattens geography and capture
Archive and history	Trouillot, *Silencing the Past* (1995). Stoler. Fuentes. Lindner, "What Was a Nomadic Tribe?" (1982)	The archive as made by capture, with a history of what it silenced. Trouillot's new State that killed the leader and took his name for its palace
Scholarship on nomadology itself	See the next page	The field in which a new nomadology works, set out by strand
The crossover canon	Braidotti's nomadic subject, Tsing, Scott, Graeber and Wengrow	Where adopters of nomadology usually turn instead of doing the disciplinary research the plateaus did. The project keeps these out of its argument by rule, citing them only as cautionary examples

ATP pages refer to the Minnesota translation of *A Thousand Plateaus* (1987), RoV to Protevi's *Regimes of Violence* (2025). Every page number comes from a reading card checked against the text (*notes/working-file/06_reading_cards.md*). Empty cells mean that no work read for this project disputes the claim.

Scholarship on nomadology

Nomadology has a scholarship of its own, which runs from the first guides to the plateaus to recent work that takes them back into their partner fields. Such strands are a beginning and not a census. Jo will add to them. Except for Protevi and Culp, titles and dates are listed from memory and still need to be checked against copies.

Strand	Work	How it uses nomadology
Guides and systematic readings	Massumi, *A User's Guide to Capitalism and Schizophrenia* (1992)	A guide to both volumes by the translator of *A Thousand Plateaus*
	Holland, *Deleuze and Guattari's A Thousand Plateaus: A Reader's Guide* (2013)	A plateau-by-plateau guide
	Bonta and Protevi, *Deleuze and Geophilosophy* (2004)	A guide and glossary that takes smooth space toward complexity theory
	Lampert, *Deleuze and Guattari's Philosophy of History* (2006)	Coexistence and simultaneity against succession
The State, capitalism, and Marx	Sibertin-Blanc, *State and Politics: Deleuze and Guattari on Marx* (2016)	The two plateaus as a theory of the State and of violence, with a limit for each process
	Thoburn, *Deleuze, Marx and Politics* (2003)	Minor politics and the refusal of work
	Holland, *Nomad Citizenship* (2011)	Markets without capitalism, and a citizenship of the nomadic
	Lazzarato, *Signs and Machines* (2014)	Machinic enslavement and social subjection in today's capitalism
	Hardt and Negri, *Empire* (2000)	Desertion and exodus of a nomadic multitude, closer to the migrant than the nomad
War, technology, and the military	DeLanda, *War in the Age of Intelligent Machines* (1991)	Military history along the machinic phylum
	Alliez and Lazzarato, *Wars and Capital* (2016)	The war machine and capital, with wars waged against populations
	Weizman, "Lethal Theory" (2006), *Hollow Land* (2007)	How theorists in the Israeli army used *A Thousand Plateaus* to move through walls
Political theory and anarchism	Patton, *Deleuze and the Political* (2000)	Capture and the war machine as concepts of political philosophy
	Nail, *Returning to Revolution* (2012), *Theory of the Border* (2016)	Nomadology and the Zapatistas, then a theory of borders and movement
	Colson, *Petit lexique philosophique de l'anarchisme* ("A Short Philosophical Lexicon of Anarchism," 2001)	Deleuze and Guattari among the anarchists
	Culp, *Dark Deleuze* (2016)	A darker Deleuze of the outside, against the joyous reading
Space and geography	Antonioli, *Géophilosophie de Deleuze et Guattari* ("Deleuze and Guattari's Geophilosophy," 2003)	Territory, the earth, and geophilosophy
	Saldanha, *Space After Deleuze* (2017)	Space and race after Deleuze
Critiques of nomadology's anthropology	Miller, "The Postidentitarian Predicament in the Footnotes of *A Thousand Plateaus*" (1993)	Traces the plateaus' nomads to the colonial anthropology in their notes, and questions the authority it lends them
	Kaplan, *Questions of Travel* (1996)	The nomad as a romantic figure of theory, at the expense of actual displacement
	Braidotti, *Nomadic Subjects* (1994)	Turns the nomad into a figure of subjectivity, the most widely adopted use of the word
Back into the partner fields	Protevi, *Political Affect* (2009), *Edges of the State* (2019), *Regimes of Violence* (2025)	The furthest return to anthropology and archaeology, adding a becoming-maroon
	Badaire	Deleuze and Guattari's critical uses of the social sciences (title to add)

Titles from memory, to be checked against copies (Protevi and Culp excepted).